
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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New United, same old problems

It has been a constant in the last two seasons: [Manchester United](#) are doing OK in a game, resembling something approaching a football team, then out of nowhere all their good work is ruined by goalkeeping incompetence somehow predictable and unpredictable. And that was exactly what happened against Arsenal, United starting fairly well, only to concede a corner and fall behind in inexcusably soft circumstances. Usually, André Onana is the man responsible, but in his absence, Altay Bayindir seized the mantle with alacrity. We can be absolutely certain that Ruben Amorim has already told his bosses he must have a new keeper and, though they have already spent heavily, the position must be addressed as a matter of urgency because if it is not, this will continue happening and they might soon be facing questions about whether a new manager is necessary. It is pointless building a swish new house only for the owners to knowingly leave the back door open, get burgled and sack the builder. **Daniel Harris**

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Match report: [Manchester United 0-1 Arsenal](#)

Ndoye and Wood spark Forest fire

When Anthony Elanga departed for Newcastle, Forest knew they would face a difficult task replacing the speedy winger. Numerous potential targets were analysed and availability ascertained but they finally selected Dan Ndoye as the man to come in. The 24-year-old started on the right and caused problems for Rico Henry with his pace and trickery. Although Ndoye is not able to reach the same speeds as Elanga, no full-back will enjoy the prospect of facing the Swiss winger. Nuno Espírito Santo tested his speed by putting him through the middle at one point, getting him to turn the [Brentford](#) defence and offer a different proposition to Chris Wood. A superbly taken header showed that there is plenty more to Ndoye's game than merely trying to reach the byline and send in a cross. In previous years, Brentford were seen as intelligent recruiters but they are being outshone by Forest. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Nottingham Forest 3-1 Brentford](#)

A Bridge too far for VAR?

New seasons bring new directives. It is, of course, hard to fault the officials for implementing the laws of the game. Even so, nobody who actually enjoys football can have enjoyed seeing Eberechi Eze's free-kick against [Chelsea](#) ruled out because of Marc Guéhi being penalised for straying within a metre of the Chelsea wall while he grappled with Moisés Caicedo. The intervention felt way too pedantic and petty from the VAR. There is talk of a light touch but this was surely too much interference. Eze's free-kick was brutal and Guéhi's positioning made no difference to whether Robert Sánchez was able to save it. Let's see, too, if this law is applied throughout the season. This often happens at the start of a campaign – new tweaks to the laws are made and there is plenty of scrutiny on them early on, only for referees to stop being as stringent a few months in. **Jacob Steinberg**

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Match report: [Chelsea 0-0 Crystal Palace](#)

Baleba's presence is priceless

Carlos Baleba, playing his first football for almost a month, showed why he is considered the next jewel off the Brighton production line. Still just 21, he was the player most in control amid an otherwise hurried, bitty midfield battle. Once he departed in the second half, Brighton lost control, and as late as Rodrigo Muniz's goal came, it became ever more probable as time dragged on. The word from within Brighton is Baleba is resolutely not for sale, Fabian Hürzeler saying afterwards: "Together, we want to go with him and make with him the next step." Brighton have each player's pathway planned out, which invariably concludes with an eventual sale. Not just yet, though, at a club where patience is seen as a virtue. Three big summer signings, teenagers Stefanos Tzimas, Charalampos Kostoulas and Tommy Watson, were all made to wait for their [Premier League](#) debuts. All must trust a process that delivers dividends for individuals and the club alike. **John Brewin**

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Match report: [Brighton 1-1 Fulham](#)

Walker faces up to fresh survival challenge

Almost 14 years after replacing him for his England debut against Spain in the days of Fabio Capello, Kyle Walker was handed his competitive Burnley debut by Scott Parker on Saturday. The 35-year-old couldn't do much to prevent either of Richarlison's goals as his former club Tottenham kicked off the Thomas Frank era in style but showed the kind of leadership that will be required if Burnley are to compete in the top flight. Walker is closing in on a century of England caps and has been selected in both of Thomas Tuchel's squads so far. He will hope that a season that is expected to be spent fighting relegation will be enough to book a spot at next year's World Cup. "At his age and the level where he's come from and what he's done, of course, this is a totally different project and something he's not probably experienced this year, what he's going to face," admitted Parker of the six-time Premier League winner with [Manchester City](#). "But I know Kyle well, and I know he'll face up to that." **Ed Aarons**

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Match report: [Tottenham 3-0 Burnley](#)

Trafford enjoys No 1 spot ... for now

Manchester City scored with each of their four shots on target at Molineux but, while the roaming midfielders Tijjani Reijnders and Rayan Cherki took most of the acclaim, down the other end of the pitch James Trafford enjoyed a fine debut. It had been a long time in the making for the goalkeeper. This summer Trafford rejoined City two years after leaving for [Burnley](#) and 10 years after first joining City aged 12 from Carlisle. There are suggestions City will move for Gianluigi Donnarumma if Ederson departs for Galatasaray as mooted but Trafford, viewed as the long-term England No 1, has staked his claim, saving smartly from Jørgen Strand Larsen when required. "He's tall, his presence is really good," said Pep Guardiola. "The fans love having homegrown players from the academy playing for us." **Ben Fisher**

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Match report: [Wolves 0-4 Manchester City](#)

Fans have to provide the entertainment

How sadly emblematic of the modern game that supporters save their most entertaining chants for criticising the financial state of the game. [Aston Villa](#) fans voiced their dissatisfaction at the governing bodies' rules ("Premier League and Uefa, your rules are fucked" didn't quite scan) that dictate they're not allowed to overspend their income by more than £105m over a three-year period for Premier League regulations, or exceed Uefa's remit to avoid paying wages at more than 70% of their revenue, which they have done every year since their 2019 promotion. How darned unfair of the authorities. Meanwhile, Newcastle fans applauded their willing workers during and at the end of their gutsy goalless draw at Villa Park before finally giving Alexander Isak both barrels by claiming there's "only one greedy bastard" as their star striker continued to make himself unavailable to play as he attempts to dig his way out to Liverpool. Will they be having a word with Yoane Wissa, who has been linked with a move to Newcastle and did not play for Brentford on Sunday? If only we had an independent body to help regulate these matters ... **Peter Lansley**

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Match report: [Aston Villa 0-0 Newcastle](#)

Pensioners and Potter in focus

Sunderland have more than 80 season ticket holders aged 85 and over. As a thank you for their support in recent, troubled, years the newly promoted club have given them all free seats for the entire campaign. It's a wonderful gesture and, after Saturday's 3-0 home win, all the evidence is that the recipients could be in for a treat. The only caveat is that Régis Le Bris's skilfully blended team cannot play West Ham every week. With Habib Diarra and Granit Xhaka – two of eight home debutants – shining, goals from Eliezer Mayenda, Dan Ballard and Wilson Isidor suggested a troubled season may await Graham Potter. "I understand the scoreline doesn't look pretty for us," said West Ham's manager. "We have to accept the criticism and we have to do better. We can't wait for the opposition to give us points." Potter must hope the improvement begins at home to Chelsea on Friday night. With Lucas Paquetá disappointing in a visiting side for whom only Jarrod Bowen really impressed the portents are not promising. **Louise Taylor**

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Match report: [Sunderland 3-0 West Ham](#)

Gunners fail to impress at Old Trafford

A win over Manchester United is an excellent start to a season; in a similar vein, it is silly to draw lasting conclusions after one game and it is not cheating to score regularly from set pieces. Watching [Arsenal](#) at Old Trafford, though, there was little sense that anything has changed over the summer: they were still solid at the back, unimaginative in midfield and uninspired in attack. Viktor Gyökeres will surely score goals, but looked nevertheless like a blunt instrument, able to run channels and physically assert without suggesting he can create for himself or settle games with a moment of brilliance. Of course, it may well be that the goals he adds are enough – Arsenal have not been far away in any of the last three seasons. Yet throughout them all, there has been a sense that, good though they are, at least one other team will be better – and that still remains the case.

Daniel Harris

Cherries picked off but ready to grow

The problem for clubs whose identity is based on buying low to sell high is that they have always to replenish – and any signing is always something of a risk. It felt Bournemouth's final league position last season didn't quite reflect how good they'd been, which in turn felt as though it might have been something of a missed opportunity, as four of their first-choice back five (if you include the goalkeeper) and Dango Ouattara all left. Perhaps they might have been slightly more solid had a couple more of those defenders remained but even though they let in four against [Liverpool](#), there were enough positive signs to suggest that they'll be at least mid-table this season. The press remained aggressive and focused enough to unsettle the champions, Evanilson was as big a handful as ever, Antoine Semenyo had an exceptional game and the new left-back Adrien Truffert showed enough to suggest he might be able to replicate the forward thrust of Milosz Kerkez.

Jonathan Wilson

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Match report: [Liverpool 4-2 Bournemouth](#)

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